



JASWANT SINGH
(RIGHT) WITH
L. K. ADVANI

Smell of a MUTINY

Jaswant Singh raises the banner of revolt as BJP rewards the architects of its defeat

| By Bhavna Vij-Aurora |

Finally it took the redoubtable Thakur to deliver the truth to the masters of defeat. A man who carries within him the harshness of the desert and the honour of soldiering, he plays politics straight. And now that he wields the *khukri* (curved knife) of the Gorkha warrior as the winner from the hills of Darjeeling, Jaswant Singh seems to have regained his fighting spirit as well. The fight this time, though, is within. Suddenly he finds himself in a party that has lost its plot and theme and is left with a few discredited characters who are more interested in sharing the spoils of wreckage than identifying the cause

of the fall or charting out a plan for renewal. His revolt brings out the deepening divide within the party that is turning out to be one of the greatest flop shows in Indian politics.

What worries Jaswant—perhaps the only elder in the BJP who is not schooled in an RSS shakha—most is the frozen conscience of the people who control the party. In a two-page letter, written in Hindi, to the party President Rajnath Singh and meant to be circulated at the core committee meeting on June 10, he is more than pained by the absence of introspection and analysis in the wake of the defeat. He has identified the architects of the defeat without naming them. But he has given enough clues in the letter: they all have been rewarded with

plum positions. (The copies of the letter have subsequently been withdrawn by the leadership.)

Singh's areas of disagreement range from election management to analysis of results to policies and ideology to personality cult. And he made it a point to explain why he did not raise these issues verbally: "While one can ponder over the written word, the demand of the verbal is instant." He wanted to put everything on record. In an obvious reference to Advani's offer to step down as leader of the Opposition after the defeat and some of his younger colleagues' eagerness to transfer the blame, Singh asked why the managers of the election are refusing to accept the responsibility for the debacle.